

FEBRUARY 17, 2026

eff.org

CLAW BACK YOUR PRIVACY

JOIN EFF



San Jose Can Protect Immigrants by Ending Flock Surveillance System

ESPAÑOL

(This appeared as [an op-ed published February 12, 2026 in the San Jose Spotlight](#), written by Huy Tran (SIREN), Jeffrey Wang (CAIR-SFBA), and Jennifer Pinsof.)

As ICE and other federal agencies continue their assault on civil liberties, local leaders are stepping up to protect their communities. This includes pushing back against automated license plate readers, or ALPRs, which are tools of mass surveillance that can be weaponized against immigrants, political dissidents and other targets.

In recent weeks, Mountain View, Los Altos Hills, Santa Cruz, East Palo Alto and Santa Clara County have begun reconsidering their ALPR programs. San Jose should join them. This dangerous technology poses an unacceptable risk to the safety of immigrants and other vulnerable populations.

ALPRs are marketed to promote public safety. But their utility is debatable and they come with significant drawbacks. They don't just track "criminals." They track everyone, all the time. Your vehicle's movements can reveal where you work, worship and obtain medical care. ALPR vendors like Flock Safety put the

location information of millions of drivers into databases, allowing anyone with access to instantly reconstruct the public's movements.

But “anyone with access” is far broader than just local police. Some California law enforcement agencies have used ALPR networks to run searches [related to immigration enforcement](#). In other situations, purported issues with the system's software have enabled federal agencies to directly access California ALPR data. This is despite the promises of ALPR vendors and clear legal prohibitions.

Communities are saying enough is enough. Just last week, police in Mountain View decided to [turn off all of the city's Flock cameras](#), following revelations that federal and other unauthorized agencies had [accessed their network](#). The cameras will remain inactive until the City Council provides further direction.

Other localities have shut off the cameras for good. In January, [Los Altos Hills terminated its contract](#) with Flock following concerns about ICE. [Santa Cruz severed relations with Flock](#), citing rising tensions with ICE. Most recently, [East Palo Alto](#) and [Santa Clara County](#) are reconsidering whether to continue their relationships with Flock, given heightened concern for the safety of immigrant communities.

California law prohibits local police from disclosing ALPR data to out-of-state or federal agencies. But [at least 75 California police agencies](#) were sharing these records out-of-state as recently as 2023. Just last year, San Francisco police allowed access to out-of-state agencies and 19 searches were [related to ICE](#).

Even without direct access, ICE can exploit local ALPR systems. One investigation found [more than 4,000 cases](#) where police had made searches on behalf of federal law enforcement, including for immigration investigations.

Increasing the risk is that law enforcement routinely searches these networks without first obtaining a warrant. In San Jose, police aren't required to have any suspicion of wrongdoing before searching ALPR databases, which contain a year's worth of data representing hundreds of millions of records. In a little over a year, San Jose police logged [more than 261,000 ALPR searches](#), or nearly 700 searches a day, all without a warrant.

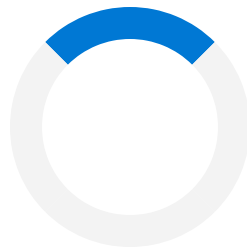
Two nonprofit organizations, SIREN and CAIR California, represented by Electronic Frontier Foundation and the ACLU of Northern California, are

currently suing to [stop San Jose's warrantless searches of ALPR data](#). But this is only the first step. A better solution is to simply turn these cameras off.

San Jose cannot afford delay. Each day these cameras remain active, they collect sensitive location data that can be misused to target immigrant families and violate fundamental freedoms. It is a risk materializing across California. City leaders must act now to shut down ALPR systems and make clear that public safety will not come at the expense of privacy, human dignity or community trust.

RELATED CASES:

[SIREN AND CAIR-CA V. SAN JOSE](#)

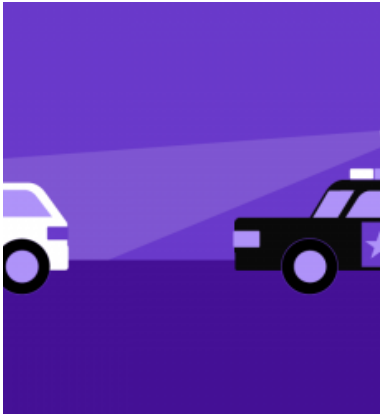


RELATED UPDATES



DEEPLINKS BLOG BY SARAH HAMID | APRIL 8, 2026

Digital Hopes, Real Power: How the Arab Spring Fueled a Global Surveillance Boom



DEEPLINKS BLOG BY MATTHEW GUARIGLIA | MARCH 26, 2026

Traffic Violation! License Plate Reader Mission Creep Is Already Here



PRESS RELEASE | MARCH 3, 2026

EFF to Supreme Court: Shut Down Unconstitutional Geofence Searches



DEEPLINKS BLOG BY SAIRA HUSSAIN | FEBRUARY 26, 2026

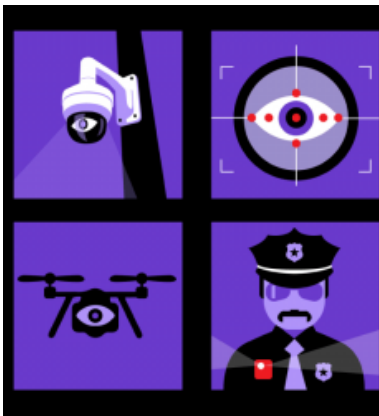
Victory! Tenth Circuit Finds Fourth Amendment Doesn't Support Broad Search of Protesters' Devices and Digital Data

New Report Helps Journalists Dig Deeper Into Police Surveillance



PRESS RELEASE | FEBRUARY 17, 2026

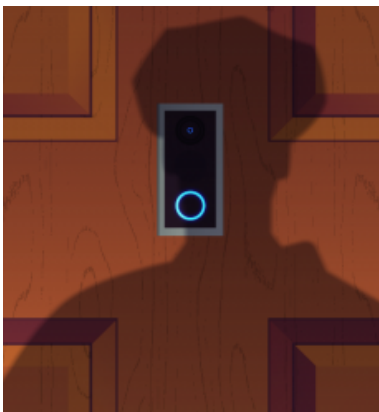
Technology



DEEPLINKS BLOG BY BERYL LIPTON, SARAH HAMID |

FEBRUARY 11, 2026

“Free” Surveillance Tech Still Comes at a High and Dangerous Cost



DEEPLINKS BLOG BY BERYL LIPTON | FEBRUARY 10, 2026

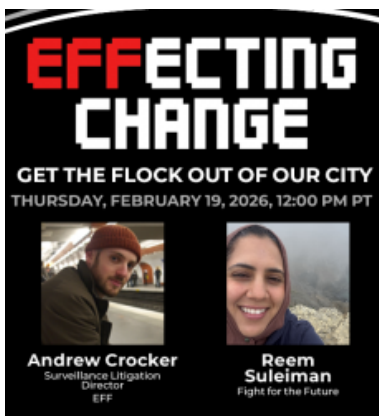
No One, Including Our Furry Friends, Will Be Safer in Ring's Surveillance Nightmare

Coalition Urges California to Revoke Permits for Federal License Plate



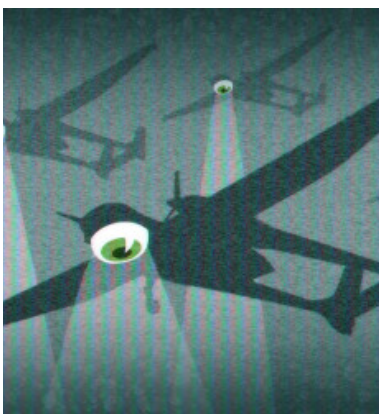
PRESS RELEASE | FEBRUARY 10, 2026

Reader Surveillance



DEEPLINKS BLOG BY MELISSA SRAGO | FEBRUARY 9, 2026

EFFecting Change: Get the Flock Out of Our City



DEEPLINKS BLOG BY BERYL LIPTON | JANUARY 16, 2026

Baton Rouge Acquires a Straight-Up Military Surveillance Drone